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Messaging the Past

Communicating Rule Sets to a Movie Audience



Before Christopher Nolan became *Interstellar*'s director and rewrote the screenplay, his brother Jonah taught me about rule sets.

To maintain the desired level of suspense in a science-fiction movie, Jonah said, the audience must be told the rules of the game, the movie's "rule set." What do the laws of physics and the technology of the era allow, and what do they forbid? If the rules are not clear, then many in the audience will expect some miraculous event to save the heroine, out of the blue, and tension will fail to mount as it should.

Of course you can't say to the audience, "Here is the rule set for this movie: . . ." It must be communicated in a subtle and natural way. And Chris is a master of this. He communicates his rule sets though the characters' dialog. Next time you watch *Interstellar* (how can you resist